

ARTIFICIAL SWEETENERS

What's the deal with artificial sweeteners? They seem like the perfect solution to reducing sugar in your diet but without having to give up that sweet taste. But are they too good to be true? That's a loaded question that doesn't have an easy yes or no answer.

First, don't fear the word "artificial." Though these sweeteners aren't considered "natural", research shows they are better for balancing blood sugar and supporting a healthy metabolism than any real sugar sweetener.

Here are the different artificial sweeteners available on the market today:

ASPARTAME (EQUAL AND NUTRASWEET)
SACCHARIN (SWEET N LOW)
SUCRALOSE (SPLENDA)
STEVIA (TRUVIA)
SUGAR ALCOHOLS (SWERVE)
ACESULFAME (SUNETT AND SWEET ONE)
MONKFRUIT



There are several potential **benefits** of using artificial sweeteners:

- **Effect on Insulin**

Real sugar, no matter what form, makes it difficult to lose or maintain weight. Sugar increases insulin, a hormone that promotes fat storage in your body. White sugar, coconut sugar, maple syrup, honey, and agave all affect blood sugar in the same way and make it easier to gain weight.

Artificial sweeteners, however, do not appear to increase insulin significantly in most people. Individualization here is key though, as some people do have an insulin response and would have difficulty losing weight when including them.

- **Great Stepping Stone**

Using artificial sweeteners is a great way to cut down on your intake of sugar! Less sugar can mean losing more weight.

Potential **Drawbacks**:

- **Gut Health**

Research is showing artificial sweeteners may disrupt the health of your gut. Your intestines have good bacteria that are responsible for healthy digestion; when you disrupt them, you may experience adverse effects including fatigue, brain fog, IBS, and more. If you suffer from any GI related issues, cutting out artificial sweeteners can sometimes greatly improve symptoms.

- **Cravings**

Artificial sweeteners are hundreds of times sweeter than regular table sugar. By using them, you can make food taste much sweeter than it normally would. Of course, as foods taste sweeter, controlling portions becomes difficult. Sweeter tasting foods also tend to make you want to eat more sweets later. So, an afternoon diet soda "pick me up" can make you crave dessert after dinner even more than before.

The Facts:

- You may have been told by someone (a personal trainer, a friend, a stranger on the street) that artificial sweeteners cause cancer. There have been many, many studies on this topic and there is nothing to prove this is true.
- If you eliminate all sweeteners, both natural and artificial, the “need” to have something sweet tends to go away and staying on track is easier.

The Bottom Line:

It's not as simple as a “Yes, include them” or “No, don't touch them.” That decision is up to you and your personal interaction with them.

If you experience an increase in cravings, difficulty in controlling your appetite, challenges with successful weight loss, worsening health issues related to a disrupted gut microbiome, or worsening blood work results, it may be reasonable to eliminate artificial sweeteners. Self-experimentation will help to determine your threshold, if any, for sweetener to maximize your success.

